The farmhouse was right next to the first team's training ground, in the shadow of the stadium itself, and we stayed there with the boys from other parts of Spain who were with Barcelona's youth team. I was still only eleven and saw one or two things that I wasn't used to from life in Chingford: in the evenings, prostitutes would walk up and down outside, on the other side of the railings, and all the older Spanish boys would be leaning out of the windows whistling at them. We used to have this hot chocolate drink at night that I liked so much I drank two one evening and made myself sick. I went to the toilet, turned the light on and saw a cockroach crawl across the floor. What was I doing here? The soccer was an experience. And so was the rest of it.

We'd go out every day with Barca's youth teams and reserve players. The training was amazing. The only catch was that Ridgeway had a Cup Final against a team called Forest United, at White Hart Lane, at the weekend. I was devastated at the prospect of missing that game; there was also my grandad, who was such a big Spurs fan and wanted to see me play there. He ended up paying for me to fly home for the game and then back to Barcelona again. There wasn't a happy ending, though. Forest United had a young Daniele Dichio playing for them, aged twelve, already seven foot tall and growing a beard. They beat us 2–1 that afternoon. Then I was straight on the plane and back to Spain, on my own and not really sure if I fancied another week away from Chingford.

Barcelona, the soccer club, was really impressive. The training facilities were excellent, although the young kids trained on a gravel field, which I wasn't used to and didn't really enjoy. The first team had an immaculate surface to play on, and the reserve team had a 20,000-seater stadium all of their own. We were taken inside the Nou Camp one day. You come up from the dressing rooms, past the club chapel that's off to one side in the tunnel, and then up a flight of stairs onto the field. Sometimes you can't help yourself: with acres of grass and the stands towering above, I started running up and down, kicking an imaginary soccer and pretending to be Mark Hughes. What would it be like, to be out there actually playing a game?

All the boys who I was training with were probably sixteen and seventeen. The two lads who'd finished second and third at Old Trafford were fifteen and nineteen. Everybody was really friendly but, at first, it was like: *What's this child with the spiky hair and the funny accent doing here?* Once we got started, everything was fine. Obviously, none of the coaches or the other players spoke English but, if we were playing, we could make ourselves understood. It was the first time I'd been in a professional set-up, training